Intersections of Racialized Experiences and Psychosocial Development for Black College Students

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Introduction

This research examines the intersections of racialized experiences and psychosocial tasks in college student development for Black undergraduates at a Predominantly White Institution (PWI). Current literature focuses on the experiences of Black college students at a PWI, particularly with respect to retention and graduation, racism, and racial micro-aggressions.

There is little discussion on how the unique challenges Black students face due to their race, occur within a normative psychosocial framework of development. We endeavor to bridge these discussions through a research study that integrates the racialized experiences of Black college students at a PWI with psychosocial development.



Limitations

Internal Validity

- Missing data was an issue. We were unable to obtain notes from 25% (n=74) of the 300 network meetings that occurred from academic year 2005-06 to 2015-16.
- A selection by treatment interaction due to the fact that students who participated in the African American Student Network (AFAM) may differ in significant ways from Black students who did not.

External Validity

- AFAM students self-selected into the group and may not represent the general population of Black students at the University.
- We only included one PWI in our study; therefore, the results may not generalize across PWIs.

Significance of the study

- Insight into racialized experiences of Black students in a developmental context.
- A lens broader than racial identity development but not predominantly focused on educational achievement or racial micro-aggressions.
- Illustration of overarching yet multidimensional nature of Blackness
- Understanding of the educational experiences of Black students, especially in predominantly White environments.

Implications

This study has implications for illuminating how Black college students grapple with the intersection of their individual and collective identities in a Predominantly White environment. It also demonstrates potential differences between Black cultural ideology and White cultural ideology that is generally more individualistic and more embracing of colorblindness. This line of research can help promote wellness and positive development for African American emerging adults.

Results

Navigating College Life (n=84 meetings)	Developing Identity (n=58 meetings)	Understanding Racism (n=57 meetings)	Getting Involved & Building Allies for Justice (n=48 meetings)	Dating (n=27 meetings)
"Black people always seemed to see college as a means to an end, i.e., job rather than an avenue for personal growth and discovery."	*Code–switching deemed inherent to survival "why can't I just be me all the time, why do I have to switch to more mainstream, standard received English in certain situations?"*	*"acting White" phenomenon or being made fun of for being smart and Black, intersection of race, class, and gender in an attempt to understand the impact of racism.*	*The responsibility to go back to the community they come from to bring people up. Some of the students disagreed, stating others can use the same skills they used to pull themselves out.*	*Students seemed to think that as long as someone does not lose their culture, dating interracially is okay. Black women approached by [p]eople looking for a "chocolate experience."*

Developing Identity
* Defining what it means to be Black
* Authenticity, transcending race
* Defying stereotypes of Blackness

Getting Involved & Building Allies for Justice
* Challenged to stand up for justice in society, Black communities & on campus

Navigating College Life
* Balancing life, finances, classes
* Lack of support and diversity

Understanding Racism
* Ways racism manifest
* Navigating racial situations

Dating
* Finding the right person
* Navigating sexuality and interracial relationships

Method

Participants

- 704 participants of the African American Student Network (AFAM)
- 54% Female, 21% Male & 24% Unknown
- In attendance were native born African Americans, recent immigrants and immigrants such as Nigerian, Liberian, Cameroonian, Somali, Kenyan, and Eritrean, biracial, multiracial and others identifying with a Black experience.

Setting

The African American Student Network (AFAM) was developed at a predominately White university in the Midwest. AFAM is an open group that meets once a week over the lunch hour and focuses on the issues and challenges faced by Black college students. The group was designed to serve undergraduates across year in school. Meetings begin with introductions and check-ins, and then discussion is generated from topics raised by students.

Procedures

- Utilized Consensual Qualitative Research
- Developed domains & core ideas utilizing notes that captured discussions from 2005-06 to 2015-16.
- Cross-analyzed initial domains.
- Discussed core ideas.
- Conducted internal audit.

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